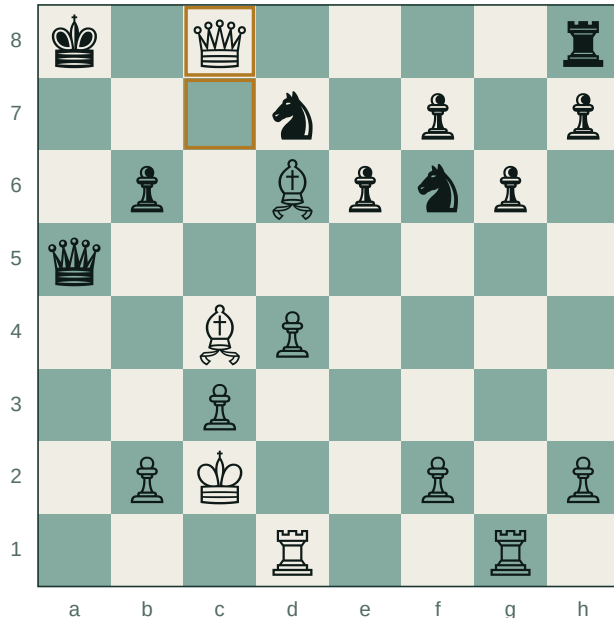


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 29

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 29.Qxc8+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

29...Rxc8 30. Ra1 Rxc4 31. Rxa5+ bxa5

29...Rxc8 The rook captures the queen on c8. Recorded reply: **30.Ra1**.

30...Rxc4 The rook captures the bishop on c4. Recorded reply: **31.Rxa5+**.

31...bxa5 The pawn captures the rook on a5.

At the end, nominal material is White 13 / Black 16 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +8. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +8:** the balance goes from -5 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on c2. Geometrically undefended: queen on c8 and bishop on d6. Check for tactical protection.